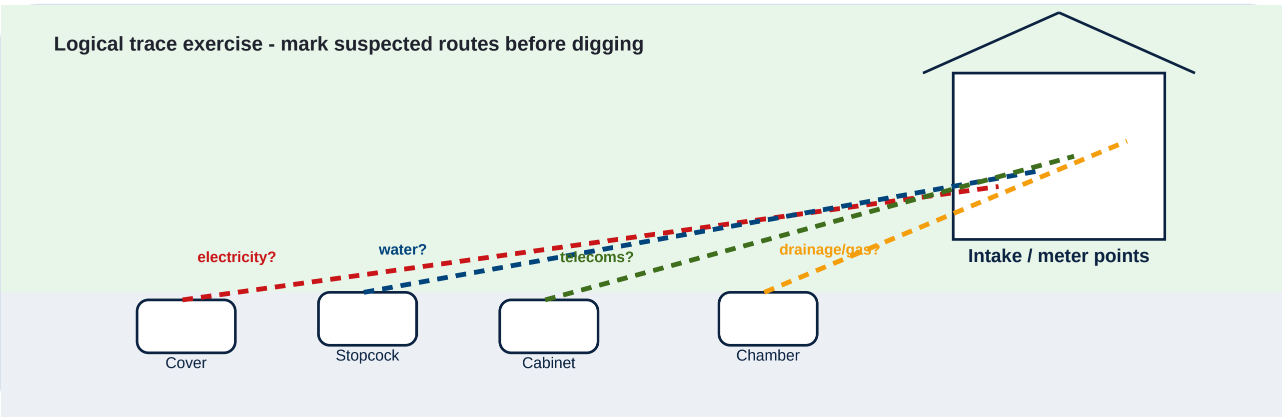
Service Connection Risk Guide

A free LSBUD Insight guide to help identify, plan around and safely manage the risk from private service connections, shallow assets and local site supplies before work begins.

Core message

Service connections are often shallow, local, private or poorly recorded. Treat assumed routes as risk clues, not proof.



Use this guide to: understand where service connections may be present, trace likely routes logically, decide when a OneCall Utility Search or Top-Up Search is appropriate, and know when survey or specialist support should be considered.

Important: this is library guidance only. It does not confirm the position, depth, condition or live status of any service.

Version 1.0 | Prepared for the LSBUD Insight Library

1. What is a service connection?

A service connection is a smaller local route that carries a utility or service from a network, main, chamber, cabinet, pole, meter, stopcock, inspection cover or other point of supply into a building, site, outbuilding, garden, yard, highway asset or piece of equipment.

Service connections matter because many strikes occur in the “last few metres” between visible features and the point where a service enters a property or site asset. These routes can be shallow, direct, angled, altered, historic, private, abandoned, repaired or unrecorded.

Practical rule

If a cover, stopcock, cabinet, meter, drain, pole, lighting column or intake is nearby, assume a route may connect to it.

Connection type	Typical clues	Why it matters
Water	Stopcock, boundary box, meter, internal intake, external tap.	Often runs from road/footway or boundary toward the property. Depth and route can vary.
Electricity	Meter box, service head, cabinet, feeder pillar, lighting column.	Can run close to boundaries, driveways, gardens and street furniture. Assume live unless proven otherwise.
Gas	Meter box, service pipe entry, regulator, visible route from road or footway.	Service pipes can be shallow or altered; damage may create immediate emergency risk.
Telecoms / fibre	Ducts, chambers, poles, wall boxes, cabinets.	Duct routes may be grouped and shallow; damage can cause service outages.
Drainage / sewer	Inspection chambers, gullies, manholes, waste outlet routes.	Private drains and old routes may not appear on standard records.

2. Where service connections are commonly found

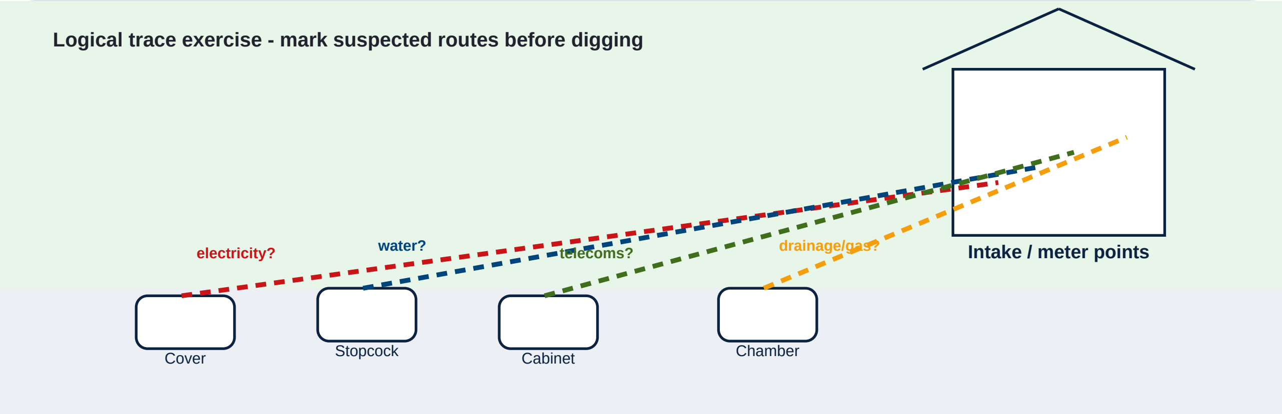
Service connections are not only found in roads. They often cross gardens, driveways, verges, footways, forecourts, compound edges, school grounds, business parks and estate roads. Risk can be higher when works are small and assumptions are made too quickly.

Work area	Connection risk clues	Common activities affected
Boundaries and fence lines	Meters, stopcocks, external taps, service entries, lighting, previous trenches, outbuildings.	Fencing, gates, hedging, landscaping, sign posts, boundary walls.
Driveways and forecourts	Routes from road to intake, gullies, drains, power to gates, EV chargers, telecoms, water.	Driveway works, resurfacing, excavation, channels, kerbs, drainage.
Gardens and domestic sites	Private supplies, garden lighting, drainage, outbuildings, historic routes, extensions.	Extensions, patios, ponds, tree planting, trenches, post holes.
Highway verge or footway	Dense utilities, ducts, cabinets, lighting columns, comms chambers.	Street furniture, resurfacing, traffic calming, signs, ducting.
Commercial estates and yards	Private networks, old supplies, drainage, fuel lines, power to equipment or gates.	Maintenance, barrier works, resurfacing, drainage, utility repairs.

Absence of an obvious feature does not mean absence of a service. Some services are concealed, redundant-looking, undocumented or only visible inside a building or compound.

3. Trace routes logically - but do not rely on logic alone

Before digging, walk the site and identify visible service clues. Trace likely lines from stopcocks, covers, meters, cabinets, chambers, poles and service entries to intake points. Mark likely routes with temporary spray paint, flags, pegs or other agreed site markings. These marks should communicate risk, not certainty.



Step	What to do	Important caution
1. Find the clues	Look for covers, chambers, stopcocks, meters, cabinets, wall boxes, intake points, drainage outlets and previous reinstatement lines.	Not every service is visible from the surface. Inside-building evidence may be needed.
2. Think like a route	Ask where the service would logically run between road/asset and the point of use.	Routes may not be straight. They may detour around historic works or site features.
3. Mark assumed corridors	Use temporary paint, flags or other markings to show suspected routes and no-dig corridors.	Marking a route does not prove location or depth. It flags where extra care is needed.
4. Compare with plans	Use OneCall, Top-Up, site records and asset owner responses to compare what is shown against what is visible.	Record conflicts and treat them as risk, not inconvenience.
5. Escalate uncertainty	If route, depth, ownership or status is unclear, consider survey, trial holes or specialist advice.	Do not use mechanical excavation close to an uncertain suspected route.

4. Risk triggers and recommended routes

The LSBUD Insight recommendation engine should use service connection clues to push users toward the right action. Guidance can be accessed as a guest, but site-specific searches, reports and quote requests may require login.

If the user is...	Risk signal	Recommended LSBUD Insight route
Householder or small builder	Extension, patio, drive, post holes, garden trenching, drainage or driveway works.	Householder checklist, Do I Need a Utility Search?, OneCall Utility Search, Select Surveys Quote if uncertainty remains.
Fencing / hedging contractor	Post holes near boundary, meter, stopcock, road edge, cabinet, outbuilding or lighting.	Fencing guidance, Service Connection Risk Guide, OneCall, Top-Up, survey quote if critical.
Groundworks / civils contractor	Excavation depth, plant, programme pressure, high consequence of strike.	OneCall, Top-Up, PAS128/GPR Survey Quote, vacuum excavation where justified.
C2 pack collator	Evidence pack depends on completeness of available utility information.	OneCall Core, Top-Up, Comprehensive Premium and 28-day reminder/resubmit workflow.
Estate or facilities manager	Repeated small works across a managed site or campus.	Pro account, contractor briefing pack, saved history, repeat searches and survey quote route.

5. What to do before work starts

Service connection risk should be managed as part of a sequence. Do not jump from “we have plans” to “safe to dig”. Plans are one input. Visible site clues, local knowledge, competent locating and safe excavation all matter.

Action	Why it matters	Completed?
Submit OneCall / LSBUD enquiry where ground disturbance is planned	Provides the core asset-search route and identifies relevant asset information for the defined area.	■
Contact non-LSBUD asset owners or use Top-Up where relevant	Some asset owners/services may not be covered by core responses.	■
Review private or site-owned records	Private services, estate drawings and historic site plans can reveal routes outside statutory records.	■
Trace and mark likely routes	Helps field teams visualise where extra caution and no-dig controls are needed.	■
Assume everything is live until proven otherwise	Reduces complacency around redundant-looking, historic or unknown services.	■
Use safe digging techniques	Hand dig, expose carefully, support services, avoid mechanical excavation near suspected routes.	■
Have emergency contacts and actions ready	If a service is damaged, response time and correct escalation matter.	■

6. Safe digging techniques near suspected connections

When service connections may be present, excavation method matters. The aim is to expose, identify and protect services before higher-risk activity continues.

Technique	Use when	Key reminder
Hand digging / careful excavation	Near suspected or known service routes, covers, meters, stopcocks, chambers, cabinets or intake points.	Use insulated tools where appropriate and avoid aggressive levering or striking.
Trial holes	A route needs to be confirmed before plant or deeper works continue.	Expose gradually and stop if evidence conflicts with records.
Cable avoidance tools and locating	As part of a competent safe system, especially where metallic or detectable services may be present.	Not all services are detectable; absence of signal is not proof of absence.
PAS128 / GPR survey	The consequences of uncertainty justify a structured survey approach.	Define scope clearly and provide site plans, work areas and known records.
Vacuum excavation	Higher consequence environments or where exposure is needed with reduced mechanical damage risk.	Still requires planning, competence and control of spoil, water and nearby assets.

Stop-work trigger

If a service is found where it was not expected, or expected where it is absent, pause and reassess the plan.

7. Service strike readiness

Preparation should include emergency contacts and immediate actions before work starts. A service strike can create risks to people, property, the environment, public networks and business continuity.

Before works	Keep ready
Emergency contacts	Asset owner emergency numbers, site manager, client representative, H&S; lead and local emergency services route where required.
Site actions	Stop work, keep people away, do not touch exposed or damaged services, isolate plant if safe, call the relevant emergency number.
Gas / fuel risk	Avoid ignition sources, evacuate where needed, do not operate switches or create sparks near suspected gas.
Electricity risk	Do not approach or touch damaged cables. Keep people and plant clear and await competent response.
Water / sewer / drainage risk	Control flooding, contamination and undermining risk. Escalate if public, environmental or structural impact is possible.
Record keeping	Record location, time, photos where safe, actions taken, people notified and instruction received.

8. Sources and limitations

This guide is original LSBUD Insight library content. It is intended to help users recognise and manage service connection risk. It does not reproduce third-party guidance in full and does not replace competent advice, legal duties, asset owner instructions or site-specific assessment.

Source	How it informed this guide
Health and Safety Executive, HSG47: Avoiding danger from underground services, Third edition, 2014.	Used as the key reference for the safe-system framing: planning the work, locating and identifying buried services, and safe excavation.
Health and Safety Executive excavation and underground services guidance.	Supports the emphasis on planning, obtaining suitable information and taking precautions before disturbing the ground.
LSBUD Insight Library and Persona Engine.	Used to connect the guide to relevant recommendations such as OneCall Utility Search, Top-Up Search, Select Surveys Quote Request, PAS128 / GPR, Large Site and Pro workflows.

Recommended action: where work may disturb the ground, use this guide as an early screening tool. Then use LSBUD Insight to access relevant guidance, run OneCall Utility Search where appropriate, and escalate to Top-Up, survey, quote or report routes where uncertainty or consequence justifies it.